

Phonetic Reductions, Elision, and Assimilation in Fast Speech — Practice

Part 1: Identify the Full Form

Each item shows a fast-speech (informal spelling) version. Write the careful, full-word form(s) it represents.

1. cansao
2. pa' mí
3. ta' bien
4. no hay na'
5. lo(h) amigo(h)
6. um beso
7. vua comer
8. miamigo

Part 2: Transcribe to Fast Speech

Rewrite each careful sentence the way it would likely sound in fast, casual speech, applying the reduction patterns from this lesson.

1. Estoy muy cansado, no he dormido nada.
2. Es para mí, ¿verdad?
3. Voy a comer algo rápido.
4. Un beso antes de irme.
5. Mi amigo dice que va a llegar tarde.

Part 3: Listening Logic

Answer each question in a full sentence.

1. Why does *un beso* often sound like *um beso* in fast speech? Name the phenomenon.
2. Why is final -s weakening more noticeable in Caribbean and coastal Spanish than in Andean Spanish?
3. What's the difference between elision and assimilation? Give one example of each.
4. Why shouldn't a learner immediately start using *pa'* and *ta'* in every sentence they speak?

Answer Key

Part 1

1. cansado
2. para mí
3. está bien
4. no hay nada
5. los amigos
6. un beso
7. voy a comer
8. mi amigo

Part 2 (sample answers — natural variation expected)

1. Toy muy cansao, no he dormío na'.
2. Es pa' mí, ¿verdá?
3. Vua comer algo rápido.
4. Um beso antes de irme.
5. Miamigo dice que va a llegar tarde.

Part 3

1. The *n* in *un* shifts to an *m* sound to match the *b* that follows — this is nasal assimilation, where one sound changes to match its neighbor.
2. Final -s weakening (aspiration or dropping) is a regional pattern that's strong in Caribbean and coastal accents but much rarer in highland/Andean Spanish, where final consonants tend to stay crisp.
3. Elision drops a sound entirely (e.g. *cansado* → *cansao*, losing the *d*); assimilation changes a sound to match a neighboring sound instead of dropping it (e.g. *un beso* → *um beso*, the *n* becoming *m*).
4. Recognizing reductions by ear is a listening skill, but reproducing them in your own speech too early — especially in formal settings — can sound unnatural or overly casual for the context; it's better to build the skill through listening first.